Travel and Expense Policy

Internal draft - approval required before employee use

Effective date: Pending approval

Policy owners: Finance and People Operations

1. Purpose and Principles

Northstar Labs reimburses reasonable, necessary, and properly documented business expenses. Employees should choose safe, practical, and cost-conscious options and must not gain or lose personal funds because of an approved business expense.

Personal expenses are not reimbursable. When a charge combines business and personal use, the employee must identify and repay or exclude the personal portion.

2. Preapproval

Overnight travel requires written manager approval before booking. International travel also requires Finance and People Operations review. A manager may require advance approval for a high-cost local expense or event even when no overnight travel occurs.

Employees should include the business purpose, destination, dates, expected attendees, and estimated cost in the approval request. Approval to travel does not waive receipt, limit, booking, or security requirements.

3. Booking and Transportation

Employees should use the designated booking channel when available. Economy airfare is standard for domestic travel and for international flight segments shorter than eight hours. A higher class requires written executive approval or a documented accommodation approved by People Operations.

Reasonable rail, public transit, rideshare, taxi, parking, toll, and rental-car costs are reimbursable when they support the business trip. Personal vehicle mileage is reimbursed at the company-published rate; fuel is not separately reimbursed for the same trip.

4. Lodging

The standard domestic lodging cap is $250 per night before taxes and mandatory fees. Employees must select a safe business hotel reasonably near the work location. A higher rate requires advance manager approval and a documented business reason, such as event pricing, accessibility, safety, or lack of compliant options.

The lodging cap does not apply to a conference hotel booked within an approved event room block, but the employee must identify the event in the expense report. Personal upgrades, minibar purchases, in-room entertainment, and costs for personal guests are not reimbursable.

5. Meals

Reasonable business-travel meals are reimbursable up to a total of $75 per day, including tax and gratuity. The daily cap is not a per diem and employees claim actual costs. Meals provided by a conference, hotel, airline, customer, or another employee should not be claimed again.

A business meal with other attendees must list the attendees and business purpose. Alcohol is reimbursable only when legal, moderate, included in the $75 daily cap, and consistent with the Code of Conduct and Reporting Policy. A manager may decline alcohol reimbursement even when the total is below the cap.

Whether a dinner is reimbursable depends on the business context. A meal during approved overnight business travel may qualify within the daily cap. An ordinary meal at an employee's primary work location, a personal dinner, or a meal during personal travel does not qualify merely because some work was discussed.

6. Receipts and Documentation

An itemized receipt is required for any individual expense above $25. Finance may request documentation for a smaller expense when the business purpose is unclear. A card slip showing only a total is not itemized documentation.

When a required receipt is unavailable, the employee must submit a missing-receipt statement explaining the vendor, date, amount, business purpose, and efforts to obtain a copy. Repeated missing receipts may result in delayed reimbursement or additional review.

7. Submitting and Receiving Reimbursement

Expense reports are due within 10 business days after the expense is incurred or the trip ends, whichever is later. The report must identify the business purpose, allocation, required approvals, and supporting documentation.

Managers review business purpose and reasonableness. Finance reviews policy compliance, accounting, and documentation. Properly approved reports are normally reimbursed within two payroll cycles. A returned report restarts processing after the employee supplies the missing information.

8. Prohibited Expenses

Northstar Labs does not reimburse:

- Personal entertainment, childcare, pet care, or sightseeing.
- Traffic, parking, or other legal fines.
- Personal clothing or toiletries, except approved emergency replacement items.
- Commuting between home and the employee's primary work location.
- Personal travel extensions or companion costs.
- Cash-equivalent purchases or costs prohibited by law or another policy.

9. Information Security During Travel

Employees working during travel must follow the Remote Work and Information Security Policy. Company devices must remain under the employee's control, confidential conversations must be protected, and public networks require the approved secure connection.

Approved business costs for secure connectivity or required adapters may be reimbursed when documented. A lost device or suspected disclosure must be reported to Information Security within one hour of discovery; an expense report does not satisfy incident reporting.

10. Exceptions and Questions

Finance owns reimbursement interpretation. People Operations reviews accommodations and employment-related requirements. Exceptions must be documented before the expense when practical. A manager's budget approval alone does not authorize an expense prohibited by this policy.